From Alerts to Actions: A Human–AI Decision System for Reliable Action Execution Under Disaster Risk

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***Abstract*—Human–AI decision systems are increasingly used in situations where an inappropriate or delayed human action can have serious consequences. Improvements in the predictive accuracy of AI do not, by themselves, translate into appropriate human action. Drawing on the joint cognitive systems perspective, which evaluates the human and the machine as a single system, we present the *Action-Centered Human–AI Decision Framework (ACHDF)*. ACHDF instantiates uncertainty-aware risk estimation, guardrailed AI recommendations, and human-in-the-loop escalation for disaster-response decision support, and it treats human action execution as the primary evaluation outcome. In a counterbalanced within-subjects study ($n = 52$), we compared an ACHDF-based prototype with a conventional dashboard in a simulated disaster-response decision task. Compared with the dashboard, the ACHDF condition was associated with a higher action execution rate, shorter response latency, lower self-reported workload (NASA–TLX), and higher perceived trust and usability. Because the two conditions differed in several features at once, the results describe the effect of the integrated ACHDF configuration rather than of individual components. We discuss implications for the design of human–AI decision support under uncertainty. Validation in other domains and with professional operators remains future work.**

***Index Terms*—Human–AI decision systems, human-in-the-loop, trust calibration, cognitive workload, action execution**

I. Introduction

HUMAN–AI decision systems are being used in situations where there is high uncertainty, high consequence, and high speed [1]–[3]. These situations include healthcare triage, supervision of autonomous transportation systems, industrial safety systems, and emergency response systems [4]–[9]. In these situations, artificial intelligence is being used to enhance the ability to predict situations accurately. However, human–machine systems research has consistently demonstrated that predictions do not always lead to human action [10]–[12]. In disaster contexts, effective response further depends on community-level coordination, resilient communications, and distributed sensing and reporting pipelines [13]–[15]. Decision making under conditions of uncertainty is an important aspect of human–machine systems research [1], [3], [9]. When there is incomplete or uncertain information, human operators are required to consider risk, confidence, and responsibility in situations where they interact with machines. Previous research has demonstrated the fundamental influence of conditions of uncertainty on human action. In the context of AI systems, conditions of uncertainty are often not well communicated or are implicit [16]–[18].

In many systems, the results of an AI's computation are displayed as a set of probabilities or as an alarm, but often without adequate support for how these probabilities should guide action [1], [18]. Ultimately, it is left to the human to close the loop between prediction and action, and often in situations of cognitive stress [12], [19]. A further important question is how human–AI systems can be designed for decision-making under uncertainty [10]. Machine learning advances have greatly enhanced the accuracy of predictions for a broad range of applications [2], [20]. However, human factors research has also suggested that accuracy does not necessarily translate into human performance [3], [10]. For example, humans might wait for confirmation before acting, or might choose not to follow an AI's advice when it is not trusted, or might become overly reliant on an AI when its accuracy is overstated [12], [21], [22]. This illustrates one of the important shortcomings associated with prediction-focused system design approaches. The execution of human actions not only depends on what the system predicts but also on how the prediction is communicated and how the system provides control to the user. Without specific tools to address issues like trust calibration, workload management, and human override, there is a risk that the system could exacerbate automation bias or cognitive workload, thus negating the benefits of the system [1], [12], [19], [23].

While there has been extensive research on issues like automation, trust, and decision-making, there is a lack of empirical research on how specific human–AI system design decisions influence measurable action execution outcomes. The evaluation of most human–AI systems has been conducted on the basis of their prediction accuracy or usability, not on how well the system enables the human to execute appropriate actions under uncertain conditions [3], [9]–[11].

These concerns are not new to cognitive systems engineering. The joint cognitive systems (JCS) perspective holds that a human and a machine working together form a single cognitive system, and that this system should be evaluated by the outcomes it jointly produces, not by the performance of the machine alone [24], [25]. Research on adaptive automation and levels of automation has likewise studied how support should change with task demands while keeping the human in control [26]–[28]. Much current work on AI-based decision support, however, still evaluates systems by prediction accuracy or usability rather than by whether the human–AI system produces appropriate and timely action [3], [9]–[11]. This paper applies

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the JCS perspective to AI-assisted disaster-response decision support and tests it empirically.

We address the following, deliberately scoped research question:

> *Compared with a conventional dashboard, is an ACHDF-based decision support system associated with better action execution in a simulated, high-uncertainty disaster-response task, and how does it relate to response latency, workload, and trust?*

We specified the following hypotheses before data collection:

- **H1 (primary):** The Action Execution Rate (AER) is higher in the AI-assisted (ACHDF) condition than in the baseline condition.
- **H2 (secondary):** Response latency is shorter in the AI-assisted condition.
- **H3 (secondary):** Self-reported workload (NASA–TLX) is lower in the AI-assisted condition.
- **H4 (secondary):** Perceived trust and usability are higher in the AI-assisted condition.

In this study, action execution is the primary outcome. Response latency, workload, trust, and usability are secondary outcomes. Trust and workload also act as *design considerations* that shaped how information is presented, but the implemented system does not measure or adapt to them at run time (Section III-A).

The contributions of this paper are as follows. First, we apply the JCS principle of evaluating joint human–machine outcomes to AI-assisted disaster decision support, and we operationalize action execution in a way that separates action correctness from timeliness. The principle itself is established in cognitive systems engineering [24], [25]. Our contribution is to make it concrete for an application area where AI systems are usually evaluated by accuracy alone. Second, we present ACHDF, a domain-specific instantiation of the JCS and adaptive function allocation perspectives that combines uncertainty-aware risk estimation, guardrailed AI recommendations, and uncertainty- and criticality-triggered escalation, while the human keeps final decision authority. Third, we report a controlled within-subjects evaluation ($n = 52$) that compares the integrated ACHDF configuration with a conventional dashboard on action execution, response latency, workload, trust, and usability. Because several features differed between conditions, this evaluation does not isolate the contribution of individual ACHDF components.

II. Related Work

This section reviews four research streams that ACHDF builds on: joint cognitive systems and adaptive function allocation, which form the conceptual basis of the framework; human–machine decision support; trust, workload, and automation bias; and AI assistance in high-stakes environments. It closes with a short note on the information sources that feed disaster decision support.

A. Joint Cognitive Systems and Adaptive Function Allocation

Cognitive systems engineering treats a human operator and the technology the operator works with as a *joint cognitive system* (JCS). The unit of analysis is the joint system and the outcomes it produces in its work environment, not the machine's internal performance [24], [25]. From this perspective, evaluating decision support by the actions the joint system executes is a natural consequence of the design stance, not a new concept. ACHDF adopts this stance explicitly.

A second relevant body of work addresses how functions should be allocated between humans and automation. Parasuraman *et al.* distinguish types of automation (information acquisition, information analysis, decision selection, and action implementation) and levels of automation within each type [26]. Adaptive automation changes the level or type of support in response to task demands, operator state, or critical events [27], [28]. Empirical studies show that intermediate levels of decision support can improve performance, but that higher levels can reduce situation awareness and leave operators poorly prepared to intervene when automation fails [27], [29].

ACHDF relates to this literature in three ways. (i) In the terms of Parasuraman *et al.* [26], it automates information analysis and decision selection (risk estimation and recommendation), but it never automates action implementation: the human always executes the action. (ii) Its adaptation is *event-triggered*. The form of support changes when estimated uncertainty, action criticality, or a policy check crosses a threshold (Algorithm 1), not in response to measured operator workload or physiological state. (iii) What changes is the *level and form of AI support*, from a bounded recommendation to an escalated presentation of evidence and options. Decision authority does not move between the AI and the human. ACHDF therefore does not propose a new allocation theory. It is a domain-specific instantiation of these principles for AI-generated recommendations in disaster response.

B. Human–Machine Decision Support Systems

The human-machine decision support systems were widely researched in the context of supervisory control, command and control systems, and complex socio-technical systems [1], [3], [12]. The research in this domain initially focused on the potential of automation in supporting human decisions in terms of enhancing the speed and consistency of information processing and the potential dangers of misallocating functions between humans and automation systems [12], [19]. More recent research has highlighted the importance of not only the quality of decision support information, but also the manner in which recommendations are incorporated into human decision-making processes [10], [11]. Systems that are limited to information display or prediction may place the burden of interpretation and decision-making on the human user, especially in time-critical situations [1], [2]. Recent research, therefore, suggests the need for decision support systems that go beyond information display to provide actionable recommendations while maintaining human control and responsibility [3], [30].

C. Trust, Workload, and Automation Bias

Trust and cognitive workload are important constructs used to explain the performance of human–machine systems [1], [12]. Trust in automation is commonly defined as the attitude that an agent will help achieve an individual's goals in a situation characterized by uncertainty and vulnerability. *Appropriate*

(calibrated) trust means that reliance matches the actual capabilities of the automation [31]. Over-trust can lead to misuse and automation bias, in which errors made by the automation go undetected. Under-trust leads to disuse of useful support [21], [22], [29], [31].

Automation bias and complacency are most likely when automation is highly but not perfectly reliable and when its uncertainty is not represented [17], [29]. Representing uncertainty and giving humans the opportunity to verify decisions has been proposed as a way to support appropriate reliance [1], [18]. Assessing calibration directly requires comparing reliance with the correctness of the automation's advice, including trials in which the advice is wrong [29], [31]. Workload is commonly measured with the NASA Task Load Index (NASA–TLX) [32] and has been examined as a factor in the relationship between automation and performance [3], [12]. Decision support that reduces information integration and action selection demands is expected to reduce workload and response time [10], [11].

D. AI Assistance in High-Stakes Environments

In high-stakes environments such as healthcare, aviation, and emergency management, AI-assisted decision systems are being increasingly employed to facilitate time-critical decisions [1], [2], [6], [7]. Although machine learning has helped improve the predictive accuracy of AI systems in such environments, empirical studies have demonstrated that the predictive ability of AI does not guarantee better human performance [3], [10].

Recent studies on responsible and explainable AI have emphasized the importance of human-in-the-loop controls and governance structures in AI development, particularly in safety-critical applications [2], [17], [18], [30]. However, most studies are either conceptual or algorithm-centric and do not investigate human behavioral outcomes. There has been limited empirical research on the impact of specific AI system designs such as uncertainty-aware escalation and guardrails on the execution of actions by humans [1], [10].

E. Information Sources for Disaster Decision Support

In disaster response, the input to the risk-modeling layer of ACHDF (Section III) comes from heterogeneous sensor networks, ad hoc communications, and community reporting, whose robustness affects the quality of the signal available for decision making [13]–[15]. Network-analytic methods such as community detection have been used to structure such large and noisy information environments [23], [33]–[45]. These upstream methods are outside the scope of this paper. They are mentioned only because the uncertainty that ACHDF must represent originates in them.

III. System Overview and Architecture

This section introduces the proposed human–AI decision system and its architectural elements. The system is non-autonomous and human-centric: the AI analyzes information and proposes options, and the human decides and acts. The architecture follows the **Action-Centered Human–AI Decision Framework (ACHDF)**, which, following the joint cognitive systems perspective [24], [25], treats the human operator and the AI as one decision system and takes appropriate human action as the system's goal.



Fig. 1. Conceptual design layers of the Action-Centered Human–AI Decision Framework (ACHDF). The framework structures human–AI decision support into four layered components: environment and uncertainty context, uncertainty-aware risk modeling, guardrailed AI decision support, and preserved human authority and accountability. Trust and cognitive workload are design considerations that guided interface design and are measured as evaluation outcomes. They are not adapted at run time (Table I).

A conceptual overview of the proposed action-centered architecture is illustrated in Fig. 1. As shown in the figure, ACHDF is organized into four primary design layers. The *environment and uncertainty context* layer captures incomplete, time-pressured, and asymmetric risk conditions that characterize high-stakes decision ecologies. Built on top of this, the *uncertainty-aware risk modeling* layer produces probabilistic risk estimates together with explicit confidence and uncertainty bounds. These estimates are then translated into constrained, policy-aligned options within the *guardrailed AI decision support* layer, which ensures that generated recommendations remain consistent with operational and safety constraints. Finally, the *human authority and accountability* layer preserves human control through oversight, override, and responsibility mechanisms. The two cross-cutting elements at the bottom of the figure, trust and cognitive ergonomics, are design considerations. They determined which cues are shown (e.g., explicit uncertainty indicators) and how much information is shown at once. The implemented system does not measure them or adapt to them at run time.

The run-time behavior of these layers is depicted in Fig. 2. When model uncertainty is low and the action is not critical, the system presents a tightly scoped, action-oriented recommendation. We call this mode *bounded autonomy*. The term refers only to the AI's freedom in *generating* a recommendation, which is bounded by guardrails. It does not mean that the AI executes actions or holds decision authority. When uncertainty, criticality, or a policy check exceeds its threshold, the system switches to *escalation*: instead of a single recommendation, it presents the evidence and the available options and explicitly asks the

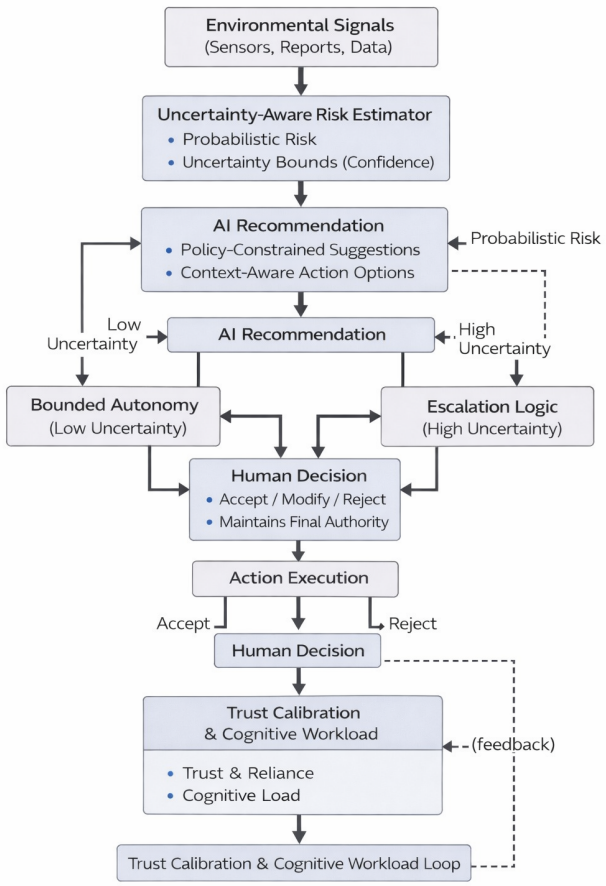


Fig. 2. Operational workflow of the proposed human–AI decision system. Depending on estimated uncertainty, action criticality, and policy checks, the system either presents a bounded recommendation or escalates the case for human review with evidence and options. In both modes, the human operator holds final decision and execution authority.

operator to review them, and the operator can approve, modify, or reject the suggested action. Thus, what varies between the two modes is the *level and form of AI support*. Final decision and execution authority stays with the human in both modes. Operator responses and outcomes are logged for audit and for offline recalibration of the thresholds.

A. Constructs and Their Roles

Table I summarizes the role of each ACHDF construct, i.e., whether it is a design input, a system state, a design consideration, or an evaluation outcome, together with its operational definition in the implemented system.

B. Design Goals and Human-in-the-Loop Principles

The design of the proposed system is informed by three key goals that are derived from the fundamental principles of ACHDF.

Goal 1 — Enabling Human Action Execution. The system should support *human action execution* effectively, as opposed to only improving situational awareness and prediction accuracy.

Goal 2 — Supporting Appropriate Trust. The system should support appropriate trust [31] by making its uncertainty, model limitations, and potential failure modes explicit, so that users can judge when to rely on its outputs and when to rely on their own judgment.

Goal 3 — Preserving Human Authority. The system should preserve human authority in high-risk decisions. Human operators always hold the final decision-making and execution authority.

To meet these goals, the AI provides decision scaffolding and action-oriented recommendations, and the human remains responsible for executing actions. In the terms of Parasuraman *et al.* [26], the system automates information analysis and decision selection, but not action implementation. The level and form of support are adapted to the estimated uncertainty and the criticality of the action (uncertainty-governed adaptation of support).

C. Probabilistic Risk Estimation With Uncertainty

The risk estimation module provides risk assessments together with uncertainty representations. Rather than a point estimate, the module outputs a posterior risk distribution, from which the risk level r and the uncertainty u are derived. **[TODO: Specify the model class (e.g., Bayesian/ensemble model), its inputs (hazard, exposure, vulnerability features), how the posterior and the epistemic uncertainty are estimated, how calibration was checked (e.g., reliability diagram, expected calibration error), and the data used. If the risk values in the experiment were scripted per scenario rather than produced on line by the model, state this explicitly.]**

Role in ACHDF. The risk level is interpreted together with its uncertainty to decide whether the system presents a bounded recommendation or escalates (Algorithm 1). Explicitly representing uncertainty is intended to avoid conveying false precision.

D. Guardrailed AI Recommendation Module

A generative AI module converts the risk estimate into a recommended action and a short justification.

Role in ACHDF. Every generated recommendation passes through guardrails before it is shown: (i) a *consistency check* ensures that the recommended action does not contradict the risk estimate (e.g., no "no action needed" message when $r \geq \tau_r$); (ii) a *scope check* ensures that the recommendation is selected from the set of permitted actions for the scenario; and (iii) a *policy check* ensures compliance with operational and safety rules. A recommendation that fails any check is not shown; instead, the case is escalated ($v = 1$). **[TODO: Confirm and detail the actual implementation: model used, prompt/template, the list of permitted actions, the specific rules, and an example of a blocked output.]** Each recommendation is displayed with its criticality and confidence cues. By bounding the generative output within a structured decision process, the module aims to keep AI support assistive rather than prescriptive and to limit hallucination and overgeneralization.

E. Human Override and Escalation Mechanisms

Escalation follows the policy in Algorithm 1. The system escalates a case to the operator if *any* of three conditions holds: the uncertainty exceeds τ_u, the criticality of the action exceeds τ_c, or a guardrail policy check fails ($v = 1$). Escalation

TABLE I
ACHDF CONSTRUCTS: ROLE, OPERATIONAL DEFINITION, AND IMPLEMENTATION

Construct	Role in ACHDF	Operational definition / implementation
Uncertainty u	Design input; determines system mode	Dispersion of the posterior risk estimate (Section III-C). **[TODO: state estimator (e.g., width of 90% credible interval, ensemble variance), scale, and threshold τ_u]**.
Criticality c	Design input; determines system mode	Severity of the consequences if the recommended action is wrong or delayed (cost of error). **[TODO: state scale (e.g., ordinal 1–3 from scenario severity, exposed population, irreversibility), who assigned it, and threshold τ_c]**.
Guardrails	Constraint on recommendation generation	Rule-based checks applied to every generated recommendation (Section III-D). A recommendation that fails a check is withheld and the case is escalated ($v = 1$ in Algorithm 1).
Bounded autonomy	System mode ("recommend")	The AI presents one scoped, guardrail-checked recommendation. The AI never executes actions; the human decides and acts.
Escalation	System mode ("escalate")	Triggered if $u \geq \tau_u$, $c \geq \tau_c$, or a policy check fails ($v = 1$). The system presents evidence and options and asks the operator to approve, modify, or reject.
Trust	Design consideration; secondary outcome	Shaped interface design (explicit uncertainty and criticality cues). Measured post-condition by questionnaire (Section IV-E). Not adapted at run time.
Workload	Design consideration; secondary outcome	Shaped interface design (single consolidated view, action-oriented phrasing). Measured post-condition by NASA–TLX [32]. Not adapted at run time.
Action execution	Primary outcome	Measured by AER, decomposed into correct-action rate and timeliness (Section IV-E).

Algorithm 1 Uncertainty-aware escalation and human override policy

Require: risk estimate r, uncertainty u, action criticality c
Require: policy-violation flag $v \in \{0, 1\}$ from guardrail checks
Require: thresholds τ_r, τ_u, τ_c

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MODE ← "assist"
if u ≥ τ_u or c ≥ τ_c or v = 1 then
    MODE ← "escalate"                ▷ route to human review
else if r ≥ τ_r then
    MODE ← "recommend"               ▷ bounded autonomy
else
    MODE ← "monitor"
end if
if MODE = "escalate" then
    Present evidence and options to operator
    Operator selects: approve / modify / reject
else if MODE = "recommend" then
    Present guardrail-checked recommendation
    Operator decides and executes (or overrides)
end if
Log decision context and outcome for audit and calibration
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is not a failure mode. It is a deliberate change in the form of support that keeps the operator accountable under uncertainty. In every mode, operators can accept, modify, or reject the AI's recommendation, and all of these operations are logged for accountability. Showing a single consolidated recommendation in routine cases is intended to reduce the amount of information operators must process in time-critical situations. This adaptation of the level of support (a scoped recommendation in routine situations, a full review in uncertain or critical ones) follows established principles of adaptive automation [26], [28] and does not transfer decision authority to the AI.

F. Potential Transferability Across Decision Ecologies

The architecture was instantiated and evaluated only in disaster response. The design principles, however, address a structural class of *decision ecologies* characterized by high uncertainty, asymmetric costs of error, time pressure, and human accountability. Table II maps these characteristics to three other domains (autonomous driving supervision, medical triage or diagnostic support, and military safety automation) to show where uncertainty-aware adaptation of support *could* play a similar role. This mapping is a hypothesis for future work, not an empirical result. In particular, time scales, operator expertise, and regulatory constraints differ substantially across these domains (Section VII).

IV. EXPERIMENTAL DESIGN AND METHODS

This section describes the controlled user study that compared the ACHDF-based system with a conventional dashboard. The study is the only empirical evaluation reported in this paper.

A. Study Design and Conditions

We used a within-subjects design with two conditions: a *baseline* condition and an *AI-assisted* (ACHDF) condition. The order of the conditions was counterbalanced across participants to control for order and learning effects. Both conditions used the same underlying scenario data. **[TODO: State whether identical or matched-but-different scenarios were used in the two conditions, and how carry-over of scenario knowledge was avoided.]**

Baseline condition. Participants used a conventional dashboard. **[TODO: Describe exactly what the dashboard showed, e.g., hazard map, sensor time series, numerical risk level, warning-level color code, and whether any uncertainty or confidence information was shown (e.g., none, or a numerical probability only).]** The dashboard gave no action recommendation. Participants had to integrate the information themselves and choose an action.

AI-assisted condition. Participants used the ACHDF-based interface, which showed the same underlying information plus (i) the risk estimate with an explicit uncertainty indicator, (ii) a criticality cue, and (iii) either a single guardrail-checked action recommendation with a short justification ("recommend" mode) or, when escalation was triggered, the evidence and options with a prompt to review ("escalate" mode). **[TODO: Describe the visual encoding of the uncertainty and criticality cues.]**

Fig. 3 compares the two interfaces. Because the AI-assisted condition differs from the baseline in several features at

TABLE II
HYPOTHESIZED MAPPING OF ACHDF DESIGN PRINCIPLES TO OTHER DECISION ECOLOGIES (NOT EMPIRICALLY TESTED)

Decision Domain	Primary Sources of Uncertainty	Asymmetry of Error Costs	Time Pressure Characteristics	Potential Role of Uncertainty-Aware Support Adaptation
Disaster Response (evaluated here)	Incomplete situational awareness, noisy sensor and report data, rapidly evolving conditions	Delayed action leads to loss of life or property; false alarms incur operational cost	Severe time pressure with dynamic escalation requirements	AI provides bounded, action-oriented recommendations under low uncertainty; high uncertainty triggers human-in-the-loop escalation to preserve accountability
Autonomous Driving Supervision	Perception uncertainty, rare edge cases, environment variability	False negatives may cause accidents; false positives reduce efficiency and trust	Sub-second to seconds-level response requirements	Low-uncertainty situations allow bounded recommendations; ambiguous or novel situations escalate to human supervision and override
Medical AI (Triage / Diagnosis)	Incomplete patient data, population-to-individual generalization limits	False negatives risk patient harm; false positives cause overtreatment	Moderate to high time pressure depending on clinical context	AI assists with risk stratification and option generation; high uncertainty or high criticality decisions defer to clinicians
Military Safety Automation	Adversarial uncertainty, incomplete intelligence, strategic deception	Incorrect action may cause catastrophic or irreversible consequences	High time pressure combined with strategic deliberation	AI supports sensemaking and constrained recommendations; final decision authority remains with human operators under uncertainty

[TODO: Insert side-by-side screenshots: (a) baseline dashboard, (b) ACHDF interface in "recommend" mode, (c) ACHDF interface in "escalate" mode, with callouts for uncertainty and criticality cues.]

Fig. 3. Interfaces used in the study. (a) Baseline dashboard. (b) ACHDF interface, recommendation mode. (c) ACHDF interface, escalation mode.

once (recommendation, action-oriented format, uncertainty cue, criticality cue, and escalation), the comparison estimates the effect of the integrated ACHDF configuration. It does not isolate the effect of any single feature.

B. Participants and Ethics

Fifty-two participants took part (Table III). Participants were recruited using stratified sampling to obtain diversity in age, gender, and technical background. **[TODO: State the recruitment source and whether participants were students, general public, or emergency-management professionals; report age mean and SD, the gender breakdown, and the number of participants with prior disaster-response or emergency-operation experience.]** Participants were not required to have domain expertise. The sample therefore does not necessarily represent trained emergency operators (Section VII).

The study protocol was **[TODO: approved by / exempted from review by [name of IRB or ethics committee], approval no. [XXXX]]**. All participants gave written informed consent before the experiment. **[TODO: State compensation, if any.]**

Sample size. **[TODO: Provide the a priori power analysis (target effect size, α, power, test), or, if none was performed, a sensitivity analysis. For example: with $n = 52$, a two-sided paired t-test at $\alpha = .05$ has 80% power to detect an effect of $d_z \approx 0.40$ (compute with G*Power or equivalent and verify).]**

C. Decision Task and Scenarios

Participants completed a series of time-limited decision tasks. In each task, they had to interpret risk information about an evolving hazard and decide which protective action to take. **[TODO: Report: (i) number of scenarios per condition; (ii) hazard types; (iii) the response options available on every trial (e.g., {issue evacuation order, issue shelter-in-place advisory, request additional information / defer, no action}); (iv) the time limit per trial; (v) the composition of scenarios by uncertainty (low/high) and criticality (low/high), and how many triggered escalation; (vi) whether any scenario contained an incorrect AI recommendation; and (vii) how scenario difficulty was matched between conditions (e.g., pilot-tested difficulty ratings, counterbalanced scenario sets).]**

TABLE III
PARTICIPANT DEMOGRAPHICS

Characteristic	Value
Total participants	52
Age, mean (SD); range	**[TODO:]**
Gender (female / male / other)	**[TODO:]**
Technical background (low / medium / high)	**[TODO:]**
Prior emergency-response experience	**[TODO:]**

Example scenario. **[TODO: Provide one worked example, for instance: "Heavy rainfall; river gauge at 85% of flood stage and rising; forecast precipitation 40–90 mm in the next 3 h (high uncertainty); 1,200 residents in the low-lying zone (high criticality). Baseline: participants see the gauge plot, rainfall map, and risk level. ACHDF: the case is escalated; the interface shows the estimated flood probability with its interval, the criticality cue, and the options. Correct action according to the reference protocol: issue an evacuation advisory within 60 s."]**

D. Training and Procedure

Before the experimental trials, each participant completed a training session on both interfaces. **[TODO: State the duration and content of training (e.g., a 10-min walkthrough plus N practice scenarios per interface), and whether participants had to meet a comprehension or performance criterion (e.g., correct answers to K comprehension questions) before proceeding.]** Participants then completed the two conditions in counterbalanced order, filled in the NASA–TLX, trust, and

TABLE IV
OUTCOME MEASURES USED IN THE CONTROLLED STUDY

Measure	Operationalization
Action Execution Rate (AER)	Proportion of trials in which the participant executed the reference-correct action within the time window T (primary outcome).
Correct-Action Rate (CAR)	Proportion of trials in which the reference-correct action was chosen, regardless of time.
On-Time Rate	Proportion of trials with any action executed within T.
Response Latency	Time from presentation of actionable information to action execution (s).
Cognitive Workload	NASA–TLX [32], overall score and subscales (0–100), post-condition.
Trust	Three items: perceived reliability, predictability, and appropriateness of recommendations (5-point Likert); composite = mean. Post-condition.
Usability	System Usability Scale (SUS) [46] (0–100), post-condition.

usability questionnaires after each condition, and took part in a short semi-structured interview at the end. **[TODO: State total session duration.]** The system logged all decisions, response times, and interactions.

E. Measures

Table IV summarizes the outcome measures.

Action Execution Rate. The AER is the proportion of trials in which the participant executed the *appropriate* action within a fixed time window T. The appropriate action for each scenario was defined in advance **[TODO: by whom, e.g., by a reference protocol based on the municipal evacuation guideline and reviewed by N domain experts]**, independently of the AI recommendation. **[TODO: Confirm independence; state T (e.g., 30 s from information onset) and how it was chosen.]** Because the AER combines correctness and timeliness, we also report its two components: the *correct-action rate* (CAR), i.e., the proportion of trials with the correct action regardless of time, and the *on-time rate*, i.e., the proportion of trials with any action within T. Every trial that does not count toward the AER falls into exactly one of three failure categories: (a) wrong action within T, (b) correct action after T, or (c) no action (or deferral) within T. This decomposition shows whether failures come from choosing the wrong action or from acting too late.

Response Latency. Response latency is the time from the display of actionable information until the participant executed an action. It is computed on all trials with an action, regardless of correctness.

Cognitive Workload. Workload was measured with the NASA–TLX [32] after each condition. **[TODO: State whether the raw (unweighted) TLX or the weighted version was used, and which subscales were administered; Table VI reports four of the six.]** Lower scores indicate lower perceived workload.

Trust. Trust was measured after each condition with three items on perceived *reliability*, *predictability*, and *appropriateness* of the system's recommendations, each rated on a 5-point Likert scale (1 = strongly disagree, 5 = strongly agree). The trust score is the mean of the three items. **[TODO: Give the exact wording of the items; state whether they were adapted from an existing instrument (e.g., Jian *et al.* [47]) or developed for this study; report internal consistency (Cronbach's α) in each condition.]** The same three constructs are used consistently throughout the paper.

Usability. Usability was measured with the System Usability Scale (SUS) [46] after each condition. The SUS consists of ten items on a 5-point scale and yields a score from 0 to 100, with higher scores indicating better perceived usability. **[TODO: Confirm that the standard SUS was used.]**

Qualitative data. Semi-structured post-task interviews were audio-recorded and transcribed. **[TODO: Describe the coding procedure: approach (e.g., thematic analysis), number of coders, codebook development, and inter-rater agreement (e.g., Cohen's κ).]**

F. Statistical Analysis

All comparisons are within-subjects (baseline vs. AI-assisted, paired by participant). For each outcome, normality of the paired differences was checked with the Shapiro–Wilk test and Q–Q plots. If normality held, a paired t-test was used; otherwise, a Wilcoxon signed-rank test was used. **[TODO: Report which test was actually applied to each outcome; Table V lists it per row. For AER, a mixed-effects logistic regression on trial-level data (participant as random intercept, condition and order as fixed effects) is a suitable alternative.]** Response latency was log-transformed before analysis if it was right-skewed.

For each outcome, we report the mean (SD) per condition, the mean paired difference with its 95% confidence interval, the test statistic, the exact p-value, and an effect size. For paired t-tests, the effect size is Cohen's d_z (mean difference divided by the SD of the differences); for Wilcoxon tests, it is the matched-pairs rank-biserial correlation r [48]. Order effects were examined by adding the condition order as a between-subjects factor (condition $\times$ order interaction).

H1 (AER) is the primary hypothesis and was tested at $\alpha = .05$. The secondary outcomes (H2–H4: latency, NASA–TLX, trust, SUS) were corrected for multiple comparisons with the Holm–Bonferroni procedure. Analyses were performed in **[TODO: software and version]**. Comparisons between escalated and non-escalated trials (Section V-C) are descriptive only, because escalation is triggered by uncertainty or criticality and the two sets of trials are therefore not comparable.

V. RESULTS

Table V reports all primary and secondary outcomes, with inferential statistics per outcome. Interpretation follows in Section VI.

A. Action Execution and Response Latency

The mean AER was 0.62 in the baseline condition and 0.81 in the AI-assisted condition (**[TODO: test statistic, p, 95% CI, effect size]**). **[TODO: Report CAR and on-time rate per condition and the distribution of failures over the three categories (wrong action within T; correct action after T; no action within T), e.g., as an additional row block or a stacked bar figure.]**

The mean response latency was 12.4 s in the baseline condition and 8.1 s in the AI-assisted condition (**[TODO: test statistic, p, 95% CI, effect size]**). Fig. 4 shows the latency

TABLE V
PRIMARY AND SECONDARY OUTCOMES: BASELINE VS. AI-ASSISTED (ACHDF), $n = 52$, WITHIN-SUBJECTS

Outcome	Baseline M (SD)	AI-assisted M (SD)	Difference [95% CI]	Test	Statistic, p	Effect size
Primary (H1)						
AER	0.62 ([TODO:])	0.81 ([TODO:])	+0.19 [[TODO:]]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]
Correct-action rate (CAR)	[TODO:]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]
On-time rate	[TODO:]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]
Secondary (H2–H4), Holm-corrected						
Response latency (s)	12.4 ([TODO:])	8.1 ([TODO:])	−4.3 [[TODO:]]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]
NASA–TLX overall (0–100)	59.8 (10.9)	46.2 (9.6)	−13.6 [[TODO:]]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]	[TODO: d_z]; $d_{av} = 1.32^{\dagger}$
Trust composite (1–5)	3.4 (0.6)	4.2 (0.5)	+0.8 [[TODO:]]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]	[TODO: d_z]; $d_{av} = 1.45^{\dagger}$
SUS (0–100)	68.5 (11.2)	81.7 (9.4)	+13.2 [[TODO:]]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]	[TODO: d_z]; $d_{av} = 1.28^{\dagger}$

†Cohen's d_{av} = mean difference / average of the two condition SDs, computed from the reported means and SDs. It does not account for the within-subject correlation and will be replaced by d_z computed from the paired data. The single effect size of $d = 0.86$ given in the previous version could not be attributed to a specific outcome and has been removed.

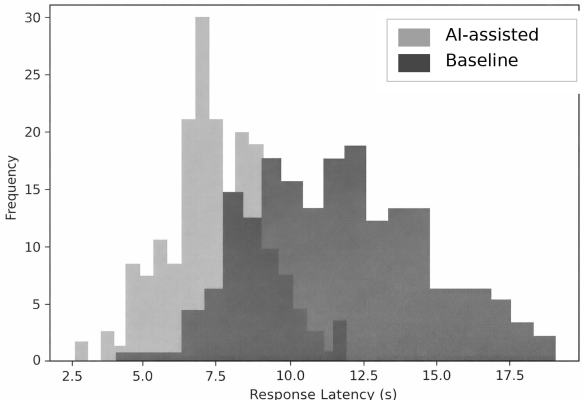


Fig. 4. Distribution of response latency under the baseline and AI-assisted conditions.

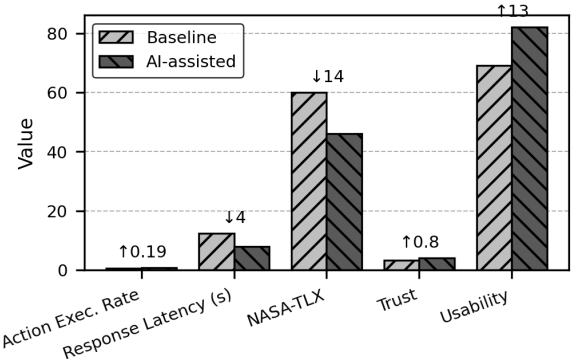


Fig. 5. Cognitive workload (NASA–TLX; lower is better), trust, and usability (higher is better) in the baseline and AI-assisted conditions.

TABLE VI
SUBSCALE SCORES, M (SD)

Subscale	Baseline	AI-assisted
NASA–TLX (0–100)		
Mental demand	63.4 (12.1)	48.7 (10.5)
Temporal demand	58.9 (11.4)	44.2 (9.8)
Effort	61.7 (13.0)	49.1 (11.2)
Frustration	55.3 (14.6)	41.8 (12.3)
Trust items (1–5)		
Perceived reliability	3.2 (0.7)	4.1 (0.6)
Perceived predictability	3.5 (0.8)	4.2 (0.6)
Perceived appropriateness	3.4 (0.6)	4.3 (0.5)

distributions. **[TODO: Report order effects (condition × order) for AER and latency.]**

B. Workload, Trust, and Usability

Fig. 5 summarizes the subjective measures, and Table VI gives the subscale scores. The overall NASA–TLX score was 59.8 (SD 10.9) in the baseline condition and 46.2 (SD 9.6) in the AI-assisted condition, a difference of 13.6 points (**[TODO: test statistic, p, 95% CI, d_z]**). The trust composite was 3.4 (SD 0.6) in the baseline condition and 4.2 (SD 0.5) in the AI-assisted condition on the 5-point scale (**[TODO: test statistic, p, 95% CI, d_z]**). The SUS score was 68.5 (SD 11.2) in the baseline condition and 81.7 (SD 9.4) in the AI-assisted condition (**[TODO: test statistic, p, 95% CI, d_z]**).

TABLE VII
BEHAVIOR IN ESCALATED VS. NON-ESCALATED TRIALS, AI-ASSISTED CONDITION (DESCRIPTIVE)

Metric	No escalation	Escalation triggered
Number of trials	[TODO:]	[TODO:]
Appropriate deferral rate	0.21	0.47
Inappropriate reliance rate	0.18	0.09

C. Escalated and Non-Escalated Trials (Descriptive)

In the AI-assisted condition, escalation was triggered on **[TODO: N of M]** trials. Table VII reports, descriptively, the rates of appropriate deferral and inappropriate reliance in escalated and non-escalated trials. **[TODO: Define "appropriate deferral" and "inappropriate reliance" operationally, e.g., inappropriate reliance = accepting the AI recommendation when it differed from the reference-correct action.]** These two sets of trials are not equivalent conditions. Escalation is triggered by high uncertainty or criticality, and it explicitly prompts human review. The differences in Table VII therefore cannot be attributed causally to escalation.

D. Qualitative Observations

Table VIII lists the themes identified in the post-task interviews, with the number of participants who expressed each theme and representative quotations.

TABLE VIII
THEMES FROM POST-TASK INTERVIEWS ($n = 52$)

Theme	n (%)	Description and representative quotation
Reduced context switching	[TODO:]	Recommendations reduced the need to cross-reference multiple sources. [TODO: quote, participant ID]
Usefulness of uncertainty cues	[TODO:]	Participants used uncertainty cues to decide when to defer or seek confirmation. [TODO: quote, participant ID]
Accountability and control	[TODO:]	The ability to override improved perceived safety and responsibility. [TODO: quote, participant ID]
[TODO: Negative or critical themes, if any]	[TODO:]	[TODO:]

VI. DISCUSSION

This section interprets the results from a human–machine systems perspective. In line with the JCS view [24], [25], we interpret the results at the level of the joint human–AI system. Because the AI-assisted condition differed from the baseline in several features at once, the interpretations below about *which* features produced the effects are hypotheses, not demonstrated causal pathways.

A. Action Execution in the Joint Human–AI System

In the AI-assisted condition, the AER was higher and response latency shorter than with the dashboard. This is consistent with H1 and H2 **[TODO: adjust after the statistics are filled in]**. Evaluating the system by action execution, rather than by prediction accuracy, follows directly from the JCS perspective. In AI decision-support research, however, evaluation is still dominated by accuracy and information quality [3], [10], [11]. Our results illustrate that what a human–AI system achieves depends on how support is structured to lead to action, not only on whether support is available.

Several features of the AI-assisted condition could explain the improvement: the presence of a recommendation, its action-oriented phrasing, the explicit uncertainty and criticality cues, and escalation. Our design does not separate these features. In particular, we cannot conclude that presenting recommendations in an action format, rather than a risk format, caused the improvement. A factorial design that varies the format while holding the other features constant is needed to test this (Section VII). **[TODO: The decomposition of the AER into correct-action rate and on-time rate shows whether the improvement came mainly from fewer wrong actions or from fewer late actions; interpret here once the data are reported.]**

B. Framework-Based Interpretation of the Results

The following interpretation organizes the observed results along the ACHDF layers. It does not test the proposed mechanisms; it is a framework-based reading of the existing outcomes. *Action level:* the higher AER and lower latency (Table V) are consistent with the idea that uncertainty-aware adaptation of support helps operators move from risk interpretation to action. *Error-structure level:* in escalated trials, appropriate deferral was more frequent and inappropriate reliance less frequent than in non-escalated trials (Table VII). Because escalation is triggered by uncertainty and criticality and itself prompts human review, this pattern is descriptive. It is compatible with, but does not demonstrate, a protective effect of escalation against over-reliance. *Process level:* interview themes on reduced context switching (Table VIII) and lower NASA–TLX scores (Table VI) suggest that the AI-assisted condition changed the decision process.

TABLE IX
OBSERVED FINDINGS AND CANDIDATE DESIGN IMPLICATIONS (TO BE TESTED COMPONENT-WISE)

Observed finding	Candidate design implication
Higher AER, lower latency	Action-oriented recommendations
Lower NASA–TLX	Consolidated information structuring
Higher perceived trust	Explicit uncertainty and criticality cues

Workload as a possible explanation. Lower workload is a plausible contributor to better action execution. The NASA–TLX, however, is a retrospective, subjective, condition-level measure, and we did not test whether the reduction in workload explains the improvement in AER (e.g., with a mediation analysis). This link should therefore be regarded as a possible explanatory mechanism, not a demonstrated pathway. **[TODO: Optional: report the within-participant correlation between the change in NASA–TLX and the change in AER.]**

C. Trust and Automation Bias

Perceived trust was higher in the AI-assisted condition. Higher trust is not the same as *calibrated* trust. Calibration requires that reliance matches the actual reliability of the advice [31]. Showing calibration would require relating trust or reliance to the correctness of the AI's recommendations, trial by trial. The greater deferral in escalated trials is also not evidence of calibration, because escalation itself prompts human review. We therefore make no claim that ACHDF calibrates trust.

Similarly, automation bias can be directly assessed only on trials in which the AI's advice is wrong, by measuring how often participants accept it [29]. **[TODO: If the scenario set contained erroneous AI recommendations, report the acceptance rate of incorrect recommendations and interpret it here. If not, keep the following sentence.]** Because the study did not systematically include erroneous recommendations, it cannot show whether ACHDF reduces automation bias. This is an important topic for future work.

D. Ecological Validity of Escalation

In the study, participants could defer a decision when the system escalated. In real time-critical emergencies, deferral may not be feasible or may itself be costly: an operator may have to act on uncertain information before an evacuation window closes. The lower inappropriate reliance observed in escalated trials may therefore not carry over to settings where deferral is constrained, and forced action under uncertainty might change both reliance and workload. Future studies should assign explicit costs to deferral and include forced-choice conditions.

E. Design Implications

Within the scope of the evaluated task, the results suggest that human–AI decision support systems may benefit from (1) representing uncertainty explicitly, (2) providing action guidance rather than only passive information display, and (3) adapting the level and form of support to uncertainty and

criticality through human-in-the-loop escalation, while leaving final authority with the human [1], [19], [26], [30]. Table IX lists these candidate implications. Because the components were not manipulated separately, each implication should be tested individually. Whether they transfer to other safety-critical domains, such as healthcare, transportation, and industrial safety [2], [49], has not been tested here (Table II).

VII. Limitations and Future Work

A. Bundled Intervention

The AI-assisted condition differed from the baseline in several features at once. The study therefore estimates the effect of the integrated ACHDF configuration and cannot attribute effects to individual components (uncertainty display, action format, escalation, guardrails). Future work should use factorial or ablation designs.

B. Trust Calibration and Automation Bias

Trust was measured as a self-reported attitude at the condition level, and the scenario set did not systematically include erroneous AI recommendations **[TODO: confirm]**. Hence, neither calibration nor automation bias could be assessed directly. Future studies should include trials with incorrect advice and measure reliance trial by trial.

C. Domain and Population Generalizability

The evaluation was conducted only with disaster-response scenarios in a simulated setting. Participants were not required to have domain expertise **[TODO: and were mostly [students / general public]]**. Trained emergency operators may behave differently: they may rely less on recommendations, use different heuristics, or experience different workload. Generalization to other domains (e.g., medical triage, autonomous driving supervision, traffic management) and to professional operators remains future work. The ecological limits of deferral (Section VI) also belong here.

D. Long-Term Trust Effects

The study captured only short-term effects within a single session. Trust and reliance may change with longer exposure to the system and to its escalation behavior, which calls for longitudinal field studies.

VIII. Conclusion

This paper presented ACHDF, an action-centered human–AI decision framework that instantiates the joint cognitive systems perspective for disaster-response decision support. ACHDF combines uncertainty-aware risk estimation, guardrailed recommendations, and uncertainty- and criticality-triggered escalation, while the human keeps final decision authority. In a within-subjects study with 52 participants, the integrated ACHDF configuration, compared with a conventional dashboard, was associated with a higher action execution rate, shorter response latency, lower self-reported workload, and higher perceived trust and usability. The study did not isolate individual components, assess trust calibration or automation bias directly, or test other domains or professional operators. These questions define the next steps toward validated design principles for human–AI decision support under uncertainty.

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